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Pedagogical Orientations and Foundations in the Discourse Emanating from the OECD's TALIS Initiative

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PEDAGOGICAL ORIENTATIONS AND FOUNDATIONS IN THE DISCOURSE EMANATING FROM THE OECD'S TALIS INITIATIVE

Anthony Cerqua, Clermont Gauthier and
Martial Dembélé

ABSTRACT

More than ever before, globalization has linked the socioeconomic development of nations to the performance of their educational systems. One of the consequences of this new focus on improving the quality of teachers is the acknowledgment of the importance of engaging more directly with what is at the center of action, that is, pedagogy (Alexander, 2008). In this perspective, we conduct research aimed at describing, analyzing, and establishing a critical portrait of the scientific bases of the pedagogical choices made by three major international organizations (OECD, UNESCO, and World Bank) with respect to teacher education and development. In terms of methodology, we conducted a fine-grained analysis of the documents produced in the framework of TALIS and semi-structured individuals interviews with five staff

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members of OECD. The idea of pedagogical pluralism constitutes a rhetorical artefact through which constructivist teaching approaches are favored.

Keywords: Pedagogy; TALIS; teacher quality; international organizations; pluralism; constructivism

INTRODUCTION

Education Ministers of OECD countries have committed to improve learning for all. This ambitious objective can only be reached if all students have access to quality education. All countries are trying to improve the quality of their schools in order to better meet ever-increasing social and economic expectations. Teachers, who represent the most important resources in educational institutions, are at the center of these efforts to improve the quality of teaching.

– OECD (2005b, p. 7)

As much for reasons of efficiency as for social justice, improving the quality of education has today become the main objective of any educational policy (Cusset, 2011). Among the many levers needed to meet this challenge, the development of teachers is among the most urgent. One of the consequences of focusing on improving the quality of teachers is a recognition of the importance of engaging more directly with what is at the heart of their action, that is, their teaching methods (Alexander, 2008).

The citation highlighted is pulled from the OECD's report entitled *Attracting, Developing and Retaining Effective Teachers* (OECD, 2005a), a project which probably provides the most complete analysis ever produced on policies implemented with regard to teachers on an international scale.¹ Launched around the year 2000, this project is a testimony to the OECD's involvement with teaching. It is also the starting point of other projects including TALIS (OECD, 2008) which nowadays is the organization's main initiative relating to policies surrounding teachers.

Because international bodies are becoming more interested in teaching practices, it becomes essential to identify the particularities of this influence on pedagogy. TALIS includes, among others, a section which deals with teaching principles and practices preferred by teachers in their classrooms. It allows for a description and an analysis of the nature and foundations of teaching orientations transmitted by the OECD through its discourse. Two questions are examined herein: (1) What particular pedagogical

orientations does OECD convey in TALIS? (2) To what extent are these orientations based on research evidence?

To answer these questions, all documents related to TALIS have been analyzed and individual and structured interviews were conducted with three analysts who worked on the project.

This chapter puts forth the results of our analyses. It is divided in four main sections, the first of which clarifies the concepts. The second presents the research objectives and methodology with an analytical grid of the literature and a portion of the interview to which participants were submitted. The third section shows the results; it starts with a summary presentation of the TALIS project and ends with an analysis of its conceptual framework and a presentation of its questionnaire, its results, and the recommendations stemming from it. The fourth and last section reprises essential data from the interviews and concludes with a discussion of the results.

THE CONTEXT

This part aims to establish the context our study. It has four sections. The first presents a shift in the educational priorities of international organizations. The second exposes how the improvement of the quality of teachers has become one of the priorities of national and international political agendas, including OECD's. The third section takes a quick look at the origins of the *evidence-based policy* movement and its appearance in the education sector. The last section defines what, for us, is research evidence in pedagogy

The Evolution of the Agendas of International Organizations in the Field of Education

One can classify the international organizations into two broad categories. The first relates to the democratization of the education system, the second to increase its effectiveness. Continuously in tension, these two dimensions are competing priorities in the lines of action of these organizations. Our understanding of the evolution of their educational orientations highlights a gradual shift from quantitative concerns – which relate to the democratization of education systems – toward more qualitative ones – which focus on improving the quality of education systems.

The shift began in the early 1960s when many economists highlighted a specific characteristic of education. By the study of the concept of investment in human capital,² they showed that the relationship between economic growth and investment in education is tangible (Psacharopoulos & Woodhall, 1988). Apart from ensuring education a permanent place in the programs of international organizations, especially in those of the OECD, this new relationship also fed a growing demand for education. Massive and unprecedented expansion of education during the 1960s and 1970s allowed access to knowledge for dozens of millions of people as well as new sections of the population, but it also spawned and left resolved many problems.

The uncontrolled democratization of access to education coupled with the socioeconomic problems of the time will cause the degradation of the quality of education in many countries, particularly in the least developed. Until then relatively overshadowed by the imperative of equality, the improvement of the quality of education will become the new objective of governments and international organizations. In the late 1980s, OECD initiated a research agenda around this objective as evidenced by the publication of *Schools and quality: An international report* (OECD, 1989) and the series of international conferences that stemmed from it the same year: *The quality of education: competencies and curricula*; *The school management and the quality of education*; *The quality of education: The role of the teacher*; *The quality of teaching: Assessment and control of the school system*.

From this point, concerns for the improvement of the quality of education will continue to grow and a look at the evolution of the objectives of *Education for all* suffices to be convinced (UNESCO, 1990, 2000, 2004, 2015). More than ever, the movement of globalization has bound the socioeconomic development of nations to the quality of their educational systems (Stewart, 1996). The requirements of quality, efficiency, and transparency of training systems have significantly increased as a result of this shift during the last 15 years. However, among the many levers to operate to achieve this goal, we will see that the improvement of the quality of teachers is one of the most important.

The Improvement of the Quality of Teachers: An Educational Priority of Political Agendas

The decisive impact of teachers on student learning is not any more really under discussion. It was repeatedly confirmed by research that shows a positive relationship between teacher quality and students learning

(Bissonnette, Richard, & Gauthier, 2006; Bressoux, 1994; Hattie, 2012). This led to the argument that if countries don't go well, education is partly responsible; we cannot improve education without raising the quality of teachers who work in schools; we must therefore focus on the education and training of teachers (Feiman-Nemser, 2001).

The consensus sketched by Feiman-Nemser will very quickly become global and in particular thanks to the dissemination by international organizations, of a discourse along the same lines. At the turn of the 1990s, improving the quality of teachers and their education and training is already present as a central issue of reforms of education systems around the world. One can easily check this in OECD's discourse. Indeed, the same year, OECD stated that "teachers are at the heart of the educational process [...] The more we attach importance to education as a whole [...] the more priority should be given to teachers who are responsible for it" (1990, pp. 9–10). This orientation will take root and even increase in importance over time. In the 2000s, the OECD published the most comprehensive analysis ever devoted to issues related to policy toward teachers internationally (OECD, 2005a) and developed TALIS (OECD, 2008). TALIS had its inception in the wake of the OECD's report entitled *Attracting, developing and retaining effective teachers* (OECD, 2005a), which pointed out a serious lack of data concerning teachers:

In many countries there are important research gaps concerning teachers, their preparation, work and careers. Such research is important not only for improving the knowledge base for teacher policy, but also as a way of introducing new information and ideas to schools and ensuring that teachers engage more actively with new knowledge. There is a particular lack of research which compares teachers' working conditions and careers with those in other professions. Much of the data and research used in teacher policy formulation is largely self-referential, and comparative information on other careers would help provide a perspective on trends and findings in regard to teachers – as well as ideas for change. (OECD, 2005b, pp. 13–14)

TALIS was created in order to bridge that research gap on teacher training and working conditions. It is the first international study to investigate specifically the training and working conditions of teachers in teaching establishments. The first study (2008) was aimed at junior secondary level teachers and was conducted in 24 countries with 75,000 teachers. The second one (2013) was larger since it encompassed 30 countries or regions, and both elementary and senior secondary schools were to be taken into account.³

TALIS aims to provide decision-makers with pertinent data by examining various important aspects of questions which are vital to today's education: the role of management and administration of today's educational

institutions; the evaluation of teachers and comments provided following these evaluations; the professional development of teachers; and teachers' principles, attitudes, and practices. As is usually the case with most OECD projects, the initiative started with the presentation of a technical report (OECD, 2008) which established the conceptual and methodological bases for the study; this was followed by a long data collection phase. TALIS is a questionnaire-based study in which almost 200 institutions are randomly identified in each country. Each director and 20 teachers are randomly invited to fill questionnaires which are different whether they are to be filled by a teacher or a director. They may be filled online or on paper in approximately 45 minutes. Answers are strictly confidential and the names of teachers, directors, or educational institutions will never be published.

Once it has been gathered, TALIS analysts start processing the data which culminates with the publication of a series of reports. The first one, *Creating effective teaching and learning environments. First result from TALIS* (OECD, 2009c), outlines the project's main results. Published in the same year, the OECD's flagship publication *Education at a glance 2009. OECD indicators* (OECD, 2009a) includes a section outlining TALIS's results. Condensed results are also published in *Highlights from education at a glance* (2009b). Three thematic reports are also published from this first experience. The first, *Teacher's professional development. Europe in international comparison. An analysis of teachers' professional development based on the OECD's Teaching and Learning International Survey (TALIS)* (OECD, 2010b) offers an overview of the problems related to professional development of teachers in many European countries. The second, *The experience of new teachers. Results from TALIS 2008* (OECD, 2012b), is a thorough reflection on how to accompany new teachers in order to facilitate their professional insertion. The third, *Teaching practices and pedagogical innovation. Evidence from TALIS* (OECD, 2012b), discusses TALIS results with regard to teachers' beliefs and practices. Finally, the TALIS team recently launched a series of short publications which bring into light data which had not yet been examined (OECD, 2012c, 2012d, 2013a, 2013b).

The Rise of Evidence-Based Policy in Education

Alongside this growing interest in improving the quality of education and teachers, the end of the 1990s was marked by the emergence of the evidence-based education movement. Before discussing the origins of this

movement, let us make sure we understand what it is. According to [Davies \(2004\)](#), evidence-based policy is an approach

that helps people make well informed decisions about policies, programmes and projects by putting the best available evidence from research at the heart of policy development and implementation [...] This approach stands in contrast to opinion-based policy, which relies heavily on either the selective use of evidence or on the untested views of individuals or groups, often inspired by ideological standpoints, prejudices or speculative conjecture. [...] the speculation of opinion based policy is being replaced by a more rigorous approach that gathers, critically appraises and uses high quality research evidence to inform policy making and professional practice. (p. 3)

The last sentence of the quote from [Davies \(2004\)](#) suggests a link between evidence-based policy and evidence-based practice. What is it exactly? Evidence-based policy and evidence-based practice draw our attention to the relationship between research and policy on the one hand, and between research and practice on the other hand. These two links are by far the most discussed, but they conceal the existence of a third that is equally important, the very one that is the rationale for evidence-based policy: the link between policy and practice.

Indeed, policy makers are not looking for evidence to satisfy their own curiosity, but to solve real problems that affect more directly practitioners than themselves.

The evidence-based dynamic was not introduced smoothly in medicine and in psychotherapy in the early 1990s ([Provencher & Guay, 2007](#)). It then spread to other spheres of public decisions such as justice, the environment, or social policy. In education, increasingly numerous calls have urged leaders to follow the example of these other fields and to give more importance to research evidence in the development of future educational reforms. The growing adherence to this movement is due to the fact that for many, in education, “[...] the adoption of instructional programs and practices has been driven more by ideology, faddism, politics, and marketing than by evidence” ([Slavin, 2008](#), p. 5). In agreement with [Slavin](#), [Shaxson \(2005, p. 102\)](#) argues that “[t]he focus on what works led to an emphasis on data rather than dogma, and on the development of various tools [...] to improve the chain of causality between evidence and advice.” To break this mode, [Slavin \(2004\)](#) recommends to first determine what actually works in education and especially in the classroom.

As predicted by [Slavin](#), the evidence-based education perspective has gradually penetrated educational research and fed criticism leveled against the lack of foundations of certain teaching approaches in vogue; the keyword being “research is the only bulwark to guard against common belief,

the effects of fashion or people who sell miracle teaching recipes” (Gauthier, Bissonnette, & Richard, 2013, p. 66). Politically, the implications of this pedagogical posture are clear: “[...] beyond any other consideration, before being introduced on a large scale in classrooms, pedagogical proposals put forward under any reform whatsoever should always have been the subject of experiments and scientific validations” (Bissonnette, Gauthier, & Richard, 2005, p. 85). To achieve this, it is still necessary to be able to define what stands as evidence in pedagogy.

“The Foundations of Teaching Orientations”: What Does This Mean?

Most authors who try to define pedagogy start from Durkheim’s essay (1922), even if many of them criticize the famous French sociologist’s proposition for its epistemological vagueness which nobody so far has been able to transcend (Gauthier, 1993; Mialaret, 1991). We believe that this ambiguity stems from an overly wide definition which amalgamates pedagogy as a practice with pedagogical research and discourse. In fact, these three elements should be examined separately.

At the outset, let us define pedagogy as a compendium of all processes related to managing classrooms and the way in which and with which the teacher instructs, socializes, and qualifies as efficiently as possible the group or groups of students under his or her responsibility. With this definition, pedagogy moves away from philosophy, and at the same time, away from its initial vocation of discourse on principles to turn exclusively to questions of methods, techniques, or tools (Monjo, 2006). In accordance with Gauthier and his collaborators (1997), the pedagogical question thus becomes how to teach groups of children so that they learn more, faster, and better? In this study, “pedagogical orientations” or “teaching orientations” will be considered as statements providing indications on the types of practices to be implemented within the classroom in order to improve students’ results.

This pedagogical question brings forth an important methodological question in terms of research: which are the studies that will allow researchers to verify the impact of a teaching process on students’ learning? Texts abound which examine methodological challenges related to evaluating the effectiveness of a given measure (Slavin, 2002, 2004, 2008). We will, herein, be using the Ellis framework (2001) which classifies studies in the field of education along three levels depending on their scientific validity. Level 1 research works are generally descriptive in nature and take the form of surveys, case studies, or laboratory conducted research. They are useful to

describe a phenomenon, observe a correlation between two variables, or present a theory, but they do not in any case allow one to check causal links between two variables. It is important to note that no theory recommending specific educational interventions can be tested scientifically only with level 1 studies (Bissonnette et al., 2005).

Level 2 research is experimental or quasi-experimental. It allows to check in class, using experimental and control groups, models, and theories proposed by level 1 research. “Thus, different teaching strategies can be applied with similar classes to compare and statistically measure their effects on student performance” (*ibid.*, p. 12). Finally, level 3 research is designed to assess the effects of educational interventions recommended from the results of level 2 research, when these interventions are implemented, for example, systematically and on a large scale in pilot projects. Compared to level 2 research, level 3 research has a lower degree of internal validity because of the larger number of variables to control. However, its degree of external or ecological validity is much higher, given the sample size and the context within which it is conducted. In this chapter, teaching orientations based on levels 2 and 3 research studies will be considered as evidence-based.

It is also important to separate pedagogy as effective teaching practices from the discourses which would define the legitimate act of teaching (Boillot & Le Du, 1993). In the past 15 years, the pedagogical discourse has been constructed on a paradigmatic opposition where the learning paradigm was to have replaced the teaching paradigm. Basically, the first one puts forth the principles and practices of constructivist and socio-constructivist teaching whereas the second one is reduced to a mere caricature of a lecture-based teaching method resorting solely to memorization and drill and practice. Because they do not recognize themselves in either of those paradigms, a growing number of researchers and practitioners are questioning the effectiveness of “(socio)-constructivist⁴ practices” and propose a third pedagogical approach which they call “instructionist,” and which proposes structured and explicit teaching methods (Archer & Hughes, 2011; Gauthier et al., 2013; Rosenshine, 2012).

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES AND METHODOLOGY

Our data-collecting strategy combines a documentary analysis as its primary method, and structured individual interviews as its secondary method. With our primary method we seek to: (1) identify and describe the teaching

orientations espoused by the OECD within the TALIS project and (2) verify to what extent these orientations are validated by research evidence on teaching effectiveness. The opinions of those working within TALIS will validate and complete the results obtained from the documentary analysis. Let us now examine the two methods used to reach those objectives.

Documentary Analysis

In order to describe and analyze the nature and foundations of pedagogical orientations favored by the OECD within the TALIS project, we have analyzed all the documentation related to this initiative. We used OECD's database to constitute our corpus. The OECD iLibrary provides its users all OECD's publications, working documents, and statistics. It is therefore the best option when searching for data or documents issued by the organization. This database contains over 72,000 entries. In addition, the OECD iLibrary's search engine does not only target the titles of the works, but also the titles of their parts and subparts, allowing a finer tracking.

According to Gheller (2009), there are three criteria for assessing the quality of a corpus: its relevance, representativeness, and completeness. A corpus is relevant if it gives the researcher answers to his questions. Our corpus allowed us to verify to what extent educational guidelines proposed by the OECD in the TALIS project are based on evidence of research; we therefore consider it relevant. The issue of representativeness is less straightforward. In this chapter we discuss only the TALIS project. Can we consider that the discourse developed as part of this project is representative of all of the OECD's discourse? It is a complex question to which the reader may find answers by referring to the research from which the data presented here are derived (Cerqua, 2015). Finally, we can describe our corpus as being comprehensive because *all* the documents published on the TALIS initiative were carefully examined using our analytical grid.

The structure of our analytical grid is based on the idea that texts contain two ways of accessing pedagogical orientations. The first is a direct approach; we see it when the author refers explicitly to the types of activities a teacher should use in his or her classroom. We applied the Ellis framework (2001) to this type of prescriptions in order to verify the threshold limit of the research on which they are based. The second is an indirect approach which operates through a filiation mechanism. For example, using the conception of the role of a teacher as proposed within a given text (mediator or facilitator), the reader can infer an author's paradigm

(the learning one) and which pedagogical approach he or she favors (discovery or project-based). Since they are based on a system of inferences, indirect approaches are more uncertain even though they still provide information on the teaching ambience within the proposed discourse.

When preparing this grid, we did not know what pathways the OECD would favor to convey their pedagogical orientations. Thus four indirect pathways of access may take various forms (four of them are listed in Table 1 for illustrative purposes).

Furthermore, we applied to all the documents in our corpus three reading levels. First, a level of strategic reading to locate in each document the parts most relevant to us. At this level, we analyze the structure of the document, review its first pages (which usually include a summary), its appendices, bibliography, and read the introductions and conclusions of each chapter closely. Then we engage in a deeper level of reading by applying our analytical grid to the sections identified at the first level. Finally, to make sure we do not forget any relevant information, we conduct a final reading that can be qualified as assisted. At this level, we undertake keyword search (e.g. teaching, pedagogy, paradigm, constructivism, explicit, structured, approach, method, learning) using the PDF-XChange Viewer. This leads to reading all entries that were left out, using the same application as at the previous level. These three reading levels provide a review of the selected documents that is both economical and comprehensive.

Table 1. Analytical Grid for Documentary Analysis.

Text	Pedagogical Orientations	
OECD 1998	<i>Direct access approach</i>	
	Types of in-class activities	Validity threshold
		Level 1
		Level 2
		Level 3
	<i>Indirect access approaches</i>	
	Conception of the student's role:	
	Conception of the teacher's role:	
	Conception of learning:	
	Conception of teaching:	

Interviews

In this study, the interviews are a secondary data collection method whose main function is to check the value of the results of our documentary analysis. To do this, we arranged for three individual and structured interviews of approximately 1 hour each with members of the TALIS team. We cannot specify the roles of the participants without the risk of revealing their identity. All we can say is that all three of them occupy positions of high responsibility; their principal mandate within the OECD is linked to the TALIS project; they are, therefore, heavily involved in the organization and management of the project.

Our interview scheme is similar to that proposed by Nelson, Leffler, and Hansen (2009) in their study *Toward a research agenda for understanding and improving the use of research evidence*. We rearranged it so that it would coincide with our research topic and established an interview scheme composed of two main sections. The first one had two main objectives: understanding how educational policies are developed within the organization and getting to know its official policy with regard to teacher training and, if needed, which pedagogical orientations are favored. This section consisted of the following four questions:

- 1.1 What are the factors driving the development of new educational policies or changes in existing policies within your organization?
- 1.2 To the contrary, what are the factors hindering the development of new educational policies or changes in existing policies within your organization?
- 1.3 Can you describe the development of a project or policy within your organization?
- 1.4 If there is one, what is the official policy of your organization in terms of teacher education and training and, above all, does this policy favor a particular pedagogical orientation? If so, what is this orientation? Can you explain how and on what basis it was adopted?

The second section of the interview scheme asked participants to reflect on the place given to research on teaching when developing educational projects or policies with regard to teacher education and training within their organization. This section consisted of the following five questions:

- 2.1 When developing training projects or educational policies, what information do you use? What information do you favor?

- 2.2 When developing training projects or educational policies, what sources of information do you use? What sources of information do you favor?
- 2.3 In your experience within the organization, what role does research play in education and how important is it in the development of training projects and educational policies concerning teacher education and training?
- 2.4 In your experience within the organization, are there mechanisms, strategies, and criteria to ensure that the research on teaching that is used is of high quality? Can you give examples?
- 2.5 Can you identify training projects or educational policies on teacher education and training in which, in your view, the research works used meet the criteria you just mentioned?

All three interviews were conducted on-site in the Paris offices of the OECD. They were recorded, listened to several times, and analyzed question by question. The aim of our analysis was to report the participants' responses as accurately as possible, compare them, and check their consistency with our documentary analysis.

RESULTS FROM THE DOCUMENTARY ANALYSIS

This section examines the nature and foundations of the pedagogical orientations brought forth within TALIS and analyzes its conceptual framework, as well as the questionnaire, the results, and the recommendations stemming from it.

Analysis of the Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework is especially important since it influences the initiative's general orientation and determines the contents and structure of the data-collecting tools. It must therefore be examined in detail.

Defining the Framework's Key Concepts

TALIS's conceptual framework articulates two forms of beliefs, three types of practices, and four teaching principles. On the teaching front, the

framework's global structure can thus be summarized with these three quotations: (1) "TALIS uses a domain-general version of two teaching and learning-related indices (constructivist and direct transmission) to cover teachers' beliefs and basic understanding of the nature of teaching and learning" (OECD, 2008, p. 37), (2) "TALIS uses a domain-general version of this triarchic model, identifying structure, student orientation, and enhanced activities as basic dimensions of teaching practices" (*ibid.*), and (3) "Educational researchers have set out to describe high-quality, effective teaching using more general, generic terms: Classroom climate, Direct instruction, Support for self-determination, Cognitive activation and challenge" (OECD, 2012b, pp. 29–30). Let us take these concepts one by one to examine how they are defined.

What is most striking is the choice to join both direct transmission and constructivism under beliefs since these two entities do not share a similar nature: the first is associated to a teaching principle whereas the second belongs with general learning theories. The absence of clear definitions does not help clarify this choice. In the absence of an understanding of the authors' comprehension of those two types of beliefs, one can identify a crucial distinction between them: the principles of direct transmission derive from research on efficient schools and teachers; constructivism is associated to a normative and theoretical approach to teaching. Armed with this distinction, TALIS's conceptual framework thus considers two perspectives: "The former [direct transmission] refers to international research in educational and teacher effectiveness, and the latter to philosophies of education, e.g. constructivism (visions of education), reform pedagogy (giving schools greater autonomy) and the concept of professional learning communities" (OECD, 2012b, p. 18).

The definitions of practices taken into consideration to analyze the manner in which teachers intervene in their classrooms are not explained in much more detail. For example, the text says: (1) "structuring practices [...] include establishing clear learning objectives, summarizing previous lessons and correcting homework" (OECD, 2009a, p. 463), (2) "learner-centered practices [...] include separating them in small groups, grouping them according to their abilities and having them self-evaluate while participating in establishing the classroom activities program" (*ibid.*), and (3) "in-depth teaching practices [...] include having students work on projects which require at least one week, devise a product, write an essay and defend their arguments" (*ibid.*).

Other further allusions, albeit brief but specific throughout our readings allowed us to partly conclude our representation of the three types of

practices but most of the time the authors only named them or outlined their supposed effects.

The OECD (2012b) also gives a summary description of the four effective teaching principles in its thematic report on teaching practices and innovations. A positive and respectful classroom climate (principle 1) is centered on students' achievement and removed from any type of disturbances. "The major facets of a positive classroom climate are: supportive teacher-student interactions, good student-student relationships, achievement orientation and an orderly learning atmosphere with clear disciplinary rules" (OECD, 2012b, pp. 29–30). With close student supervision, strongly structured lessons and the constant use of feedback, direct instruction (principle 2) maximizes effective learning time and has a positive influence on student performance, especially those who are having difficulties. Support for self-determination (principle 3) is associated to constructivist approaches and to humanist psychology which place emphasis on learners' autonomy and on their social relations with each other and with adults. For the authors, this third principle aligns the motivational and relational dimensions of the act of learning. Finally, "in order to foster 'cognitive activity' [principle 4] – rather than 'activity per se' – and conceptual understanding, instruction should use deep, challenging content (Brown, 1994). In the case of mathematics, for example, this means making connections between mathematical facts, procedures, ideas, and representations (Hiebert & Grouws, 2007). To achieve this aim, argumentation and non-routine problem solving should be promoted" (OECD, 2012b, pp. 29–30).

Articulating the Framework's Key Concepts – First Level of Understanding

Let us analyze the situation further by examining the theoretical links which tie these teaching beliefs, practices, and principles of teaching. In the first pages of the report on teaching practices and innovations (OECD, 2012b), the authors explain why it is appropriate to refer to the principles of direct transmission and constructivism when studying beliefs related to the nature of teaching and learning:

At the beginning of the 21st century, socio-constructivist ideas (i.e., examining a learner's psychological processes within the context of the learning process) became prominent in normative approaches to classroom teaching. However, research on school effectiveness suggests that practices based on these theoretical ideas are insufficient to foster student learning. Rather, a combination of clear, well-structured classroom management, supportive, student-oriented classroom climate, and cognitive activation

(e.g., challenging content that promotes deep reflection in the student) has been shown to be effective. The conceptual framework therefore incorporates both socio-constructivist thinking and more classical process-product research, which provides a way to build a bridge between constructivism and direct instruction approaches to education. (pp. 13–14)

This extract allows us to decode a first system of filiation which brings together beliefs, research currents, epistemological positioning, as well as practices and principles of teaching (Table 2).

One criticism of this first attempt at justification is its opaque character stemming among other things from an amalgamation of socio-constructivism and constructivism, confirmed by the unusual turn of phrase mentioned previously, namely that of “(socio)-constructivism.” Another source of confusion is the teaching practices and principles proposed by the authors as an alternative to the limits of socio-constructivist ideas which are presented as if they all belong to the research path of effective schools. Such is not the case, as will be evidenced from further readings. Reference to “classical” process-product research also appears to cause a problem since it can leave one with the impression that such research has not evolved since the 1970s or through a mirror effect, make the socio-constructivist way of thinking appear innovative and thus, more desirable. This extract confirms the distinction established earlier between the normative and scientific approaches to teaching.

The filiation system of TALIS’s conceptual framework can be established and elaborated on by referring to this eloquent excerpt from the thematic report (OECD, 2012b, p. 19):

Classroom teaching practices are at the core of a teacher’s work. At the beginning of the 21st century, teaching practices based on socio-constructivist theories became popular in educational philosophy (e.g., Brown, 1994; Deci and Ryan, 1985; Evensen and Hmelo, 2000; Lee and Songer, 2003; Mayer, 2004; Scardamalia and Bereiter, 2006).

Table 2. Tentative Links between the Various Concepts of TALIS’s Conceptual Framework.

Beliefs	Theories and Research	Practice and Principles
Direct transmission	Evidence-based education	Structuring practices
Constructivism	School effectiveness	Learner-centered practices
	Process-product research	Cognitive activation
	Philosophy of education	
	Normative approach	

These theories are, to a certain degree, supported by empirical research: instructional methods based on socioconstructivist ideas (i.e., examining a learner’s psychological processes within the context of the learning process) – for example, student-oriented practices and cognitive activation – are associated with student motivation and conceptual understanding. However, empirical research also suggests that these factors are not sufficient to foster learning. Cognitive outcomes may also require clear structuring of lessons and good classroom management (e.g., Baumert et al., 2009; Creemers and Kyriakides, 2008; Klieme, Pauli, and Reusser, 2009; Lipowsky et al., 2009; Pianta and Hamre, 2001). Therefore, three dimensions of classroom teaching practices are identified in TALIS 2008 that reflect all of these aspects: structuring, student orientation and enhanced activities. (OECD, 2009a, 2010a)

The basis of this message is the same as that of the preceding passage: socio-constructivist ideas and practices are not sufficient to improve student learning; they must be accompanied by classroom management and teaching methods which are better structured.

The tension between the normative portion and the scientific one is always present: socio-constructivist theories and practices are only partially supported by research whereas those stemming from direct transmission appear empirically founded. On the other hand, the first part of the extract includes a filiation linking on one hand “socio-constructivist” ideas with student-centered practices and so-called in-depth practices and, on the other hand, with the principles of self-determination (motivation) and cognitive activation (conceptual comprehension) (Table 3). So in order to return to the preceding excerpt, when they propose a classroom climate centered on students and the principle of cognitive activation to offset the limits of socio-constructivist ideas, the authors are really proposing other

Table 3. Links between the Various Concepts Within TALIS’s Conceptual Framework.

Beliefs	Theories and Research	Practices	Principle
Direct transmission	Evidence-based education Process-product research	Structuring practices	Classroom climate Direct instruction
Constructivism	Philosophy of education	Student-centered practices	Support
Socio-constructivism	Normative approach	In-depth teaching practices	Self-determination Cognitive activation and challenge

socio-constructivist principles. By acting this way, they place on an even footing the normative and the scientific approach.

At this point in the analysis, the significance and the links which unite the concepts in TALIS's framework become clearer but a better comprehension of why they were selected is still needed. In principle, the presence of normative and scientific approaches to teaching follows along a principle of complementarity: "Instructional quality is complex: There is no single best way of teaching and teachers continually must adapt their practices to serve the needs of the specific context, class and students. A combination of a constructivist and of a more direct approach to instruction is needed" (OECD, 2012b, p. 26).

This position is repeated frequently and in a variety of manners in other documents. For example, in the report which sets out TALIS's first results (OECD, 2009c, p. 89), the authors claim that "the framework of instructional quality is broader than the direct instruction described above." For them, learning opportunities must be recognized and used by students in order to become effective, which justifies the interest in constructivist approaches. The principle of complementarity is reinforced by this other affirmation: "The dimensions of these beliefs are well established in educational research at least in Western countries and have also received support elsewhere (Kim, 2005)" (OECD, 2009c, p. 92). Along the same lines, the authors propose that teachers' professional practices are borne out of teaching philosophies and in empirical research on the effectiveness of teaching, and that either of those can help identify "[...] salient aspects of the classroom learning environment" (OECD, 2012b, p. 28).

Articulation of the Framework's Key Concepts – Second Level of Understanding

The acknowledged principle of complementarity cannot stand when faced with a more thorough analysis of the contents of TALIS's conceptual framework which is less neutral than it looks. Through a variety of rhetorical processes, the authors build a sort of a framework within a framework. That latter framework is harder to discern because it is ideological since it prioritizes beliefs and practices. One can thus read (OECD, 2009b):

The direct transmission view of student learning implies that a teachers' role is to communicate knowledge in a clear and structured way, to explain correct solutions, to give students clear and resolvable problems, and to ensure calm and concentration in the classroom. In contrast, a constructivist view focuses on students not as passive

recipients but as active participants in the process of acquiring knowledge. Teachers holding this view emphasise facilitating student inquiry, prefer to give students the chance to develop solutions to problems on their own, and allow students to play active role in instructional activities. Here, the development of thinking and reasoning processes is stressed more than the acquisition of specific knowledge. (Staub & Stern, 2002, pp. 92–93)

A strictly black-and-white rhetoric is clearly at work here with the use of expressions such as “in contrast” and “more than,” and it separates itself from the initial principle of complementarity. The manner in which practices and principles are defined betrays the direct transmission approach.

Contrary to constructivist perspectives, transmissive approaches place students in the position of passive recipients in which teachers only have to transfer their specific knowledge. Inversely, with constructivist teaching strategies, learners become active participants able to acquire the most sought-after abilities in a perspective of lifelong learning, namely acquiring transversal reasoning abilities. For the OECD, constructive approaches thus liberate students and give them access to high-level abilities. The usefulness and relevance of structured approaches are diminished or at least, reduced to basic learning and managing in-class behavior.

The same prioritization mechanism happens with regard to beliefs. It can be seen in the text where authors identify the main points of what they call the evolution of learning and teaching philosophies, where they posit the following: the most recent philosophies rectify the oldest shortcomings. Thus Gestalt psychology goes against the fragmentation of behaviors brought about by behaviorism; cognitive psychology cracks open the black box abandoned by the first two types of psychology; between the 1970s and the 1980s, constructivism emerged to “overcome the limits of cognitive psychology” (OECD, 2012b, p. 28); and finally, at the end of the 20th century, “when constructivism describes learning as a process which happens in isolation in the mind of an individual” (*ibid.*, p. 29), socio-constructivism underlines the importance of the social dimension inherent to all learning processes. Going from one type of “philosophy” to another is seen as progress, an operation which places socio-constructivism as the highest and most valid theory to date to approach the teaching-learning process. Furthermore, because it is not a learning theory in the same vein as constructivism or socio-constructivism, direct transmission can easily be associated to behaviorism and thus, be tarred with the same brush and be considered as outdated.

Keeping in mind the filiation system described above, it is easy to understand that direct transmission, structuring practices, and the principles

associated with classroom climate and direct instruction are pushed aside. They may be important, but “socio-constructivist” ideas are more important, and for aspects which are even more essential. This impression is amplified when reading excerpts which more or less give credence to “(socio)-constructivist” beliefs, practices, and principles. For example, such is the case when the authors claim, on one hand, that “the notion of ‘professional learning communities’, believed to be the core of schools as ‘learning organisations’, has gained popularity among professionals as well as policy makers” (OECD, 2012b, p. 27) and on the other, that this notion is borne out of socio-constructivist ideas.

It is also the case when they pretend that “[h]igh-quality instruction is often defined as the use of a variety of classroom teaching practices” (*ibid.*, p. 16) but also that the “higher the agreement with constructivist beliefs, the more likely a teacher is to be in a profile with higher means for the three dimensions of classroom teaching practices” (*ibid.*, p. 20).^{5,6} Finally, such is the case when, on the same page, they urge that “[p]edagogical practice always needs to be innovative” (*ibid.*, p. 39), but also that “among the most recent advances in educational philosophy are teaching and learning practices associated within the socio-constructivist paradigm” (*ibid.*, p. 39).

ANALYSIS OF THE BODY OF THE QUESTIONNAIRE

Before analyzing the results of the first TALIS study, it appears relevant to examine more thoroughly the body of the questionnaire which yielded these results. This operation appears even more essential after analyzing the conceptual framework which, as we can see, benefits “(socio)-constructivist” practices. We must ensure that the questionnaire does not direct the participants’ answers – for example by referring to teaching practices which may be too traditional, or to concepts carrying a negative connotation (memorization, repetition) – yet that it proposes formulations which are sufficiently detailed to determine the types of beliefs and practices respondents adhere to. Let us start by examining those formulations which are supposed to represent the teachers’ beliefs with regard to teaching itself:

Direct transmission beliefs about instruction:

1. Effective/good teachers demonstrate the correct way to solve a problem;
2. Instruction should be built around problems with clear, correct answers, and around ideas that most students can grasp quickly;

3. How much students learn depends on how much background knowledge they have – that is why teaching facts is so necessary;
4. A quiet classroom is generally needed for effective learning.

Constructivist beliefs about instruction:

5. My role as a teacher is to facilitate students' own inquiry;
6. Students learn best by finding solutions to problems on their own;
7. Students should be allowed to think of solutions to practical problems themselves before the teacher shows them how they are solved;
8. Thinking and reasoning processes are more important than specific curriculum content. (OECD, 2008, p. 183)

As for beliefs, numerous statements are not mutually exclusive; they do not allow for a strict distinction between direct transmission and constructivism. The only one which truly permits this is Statement 6 because it goes against beliefs associated with direct transmission. On this level, the other statements are more questionable. For example, the objective dealing with allowing for a greater autonomy for students in their learning (Statement 5) is common to both sets of beliefs while the means of achieving it differs. Such is the case with structured teaching where the teacher considers that he or she must first provide close guidance before students can later work on their own (scaffolding). In the same way, it is very unlikely that teachers who declare their commitment to constructivism would reject the idea that a calm classroom is preferable for effective learning (Statement 4).

Statement 1 presents another set of problems. In absolute terms, a good teacher must be able to show students the right way of solving a problem. On that front, the difference between direct transmission and constructivism corresponds to the timing of this intervention: for those who favor structured practices, the demonstration comes at the start of the lesson; for others, it is put forth at the end if necessary. A Likert scale does not allow for identifying those subtleties. Therefore if the aim of this part of the questionnaire was to establish a distinction between two groups of teachers with regard to their beliefs, it may be that the results will not be as dramatic as forecasted. But what about statements related to practices?

“Classroom teaching practice: structuring

1. I explicitly state learning goals.
2. I review with the students the homework they have prepared.
3. I ask my students to remember every step in a procedure.
4. At the beginning of the lesson I present a short summary of the previous lesson.
5. Students evaluate and reflect upon their own work.

Classroom teaching practice: student-oriented

6. Students work in small groups to come up with a joint solution to a problem or task.
7. I give different work to the students that have difficulties learning and/or to those who can advance faster.
8. I ask my students to suggest or to help plan classroom activities or topics.
9. Students work in groups based upon their abilities.

Classroom teaching practice: enhanced activities

10. Students work on projects that require at least one week to complete.
11. Students make a product that will be used by someone else.
12. I ask my students to write an essay in which they are expected to explain their thinking or reasoning at some length.
13. Students hold a debate and argue for a particular point of view which may not be their own. (OECD, 2008, p. 191)

By admitting the categorization proposed by the authors, we may consider that statements associated to practices are significantly more discriminating but the problem identified with beliefs still remains. Here are three examples which may help illustrate it: first, there is little doubt that even the most constructivist teacher will present his or her objectives before starting a lesson; should we then pretend that Statement 9 only deals with a specific type of practice? Second, teaching customization (Statements 14 and 17) is not the exclusive property of constructivist practices; reducing it to such practices would be an error.

Finally, most teachers assign homework to their students; correcting these or not is first and foremost a question of coherence rather than adhering to one type of practice or another. But the list of practices presents a more serious problem: Statements 9–13 do not reflect a full-fledged teaching modality: as they are described, structured practices seem to only correspond to elements which are peripheral to the lessons. Granted, it is difficult to teach anything by simply setting objectives, summarizing prior learning, or correct homework. By maintaining the practices of direct transmission on the edge of teaching, the authors keep the heart of it for “(socio)-constructivist” practices. Thus the questionnaire has at its center, at least in a practical sense, the prioritization mechanism at work in the study’s conceptual framework.

Analysis of the Results

Let us examine the survey’s results and start by confirming at the outset that these are of little value to our study since a portrait of beliefs and practices adopted by teachers in some 30 countries brings no information on the teaching position of the OECD. The idea is not to provide a full and

detailed account of TALIS's results but to study the manner in which they are presented and interpreted in order to explore the elements which will help discuss the organization's pedagogical directions.

The first observation with regard to beliefs specifies that "in all countries but Italy the average endorsement of constructivist beliefs is stronger than that of direct transmission beliefs. In most countries, therefore, teachers believe that their task is not simply to present facts and give their students the opportunity to practice, but rather that they should support students in their active construction of knowledge" (OECD, 2009c, p. 94). This result is not surprising since most educational systems have recently moved to constructivist ideals. The way in which the authors devalue the beliefs in direct transmission by reducing them yet again to a simple presentation of facts coupled with drill and practice should also be noted. Numerous such turns are dispersed throughout the reports produced by the team in charge of TALIS and their accumulation tinges the text with the organization's teaching discourse.

Two other observations emerge from the report. The first deals with the percentage of variation in beliefs between countries, schools, and classrooms. "[F]or constructivist beliefs the percentage of variance is noticeably smaller on the country level, and higher on the individual level than for direct transmission beliefs" (*ibid.*, p. 96). In the authors' opinion, the percentage of variance still remains "exceptionally" high on the national level (50% for direct transmission; 25% for constructivism) whereas it is almost nil at the school level. For them, these observations suggest that teachers' beliefs "are very strongly influenced by national school systems, culture and pedagogical traditions" (*ibid.*). The other observation is on the correlation between constructivist beliefs and direct transmission beliefs.

Since these two types of beliefs are supposed to be opposed in nature (OECD, 2009c), the authors thought they would obtain negative or nil correlations. Finally, there is a degree of variable opposition between the two approaches based on countries. In some, the higher the belief in constructivism, the higher also the opposition to the principles of structured approaches; in others, the opposition is not as strong. In fact, it is even rather light, as is the case in Southern and Eastern Europe where a more integrated approach to teaching is preferred.

As for teaching practices, "structuring practices [...] are the most frequently employed practices across all participating countries [...] Enhanced activities are less frequent than student-oriented practices in all participating countries" (*ibid.*, p. 98). Whereas constructivist beliefs are adhered to by a larger number of teachers, they more often resort to direct transmission practices within their classrooms. Here is how the OECD reacts to this

observation: “It should be noted that all three of these dimensions of classroom teaching practices have been shown to be related to student outcomes, even if their correlation with outcomes is not linear and if high frequency is more meaningful for some than for others. Nevertheless, the TALIS results suggest that more use might be made of student-oriented practices and enhanced activities [...]” (*ibid.*, p. 99). The OECD thus encourages a more frequent use of “(socio)-constructivist” practices.

TALIS results also allow for a comparison between the uses of three different types of practices depending on the discipline being taught. The authors believe that extensive and structured practices centered on the learner are useful in all disciplines, but they note that in technical areas and in hard sciences, except for physics, structured practices are preferred. It is the exact opposite in human and social sciences. Here is what the authors have to say with regard to this second observation:

These results emphasise the importance of the humanities and creative and practical subjects, as these seem to offer learning experiences which are less often provided in mathematics, science and foreign language classes. Student-oriented practices and enhanced activities, which are more often used in the former subjects, allow students to take responsibility and to self-organise and they help develop a broad spectrum of skills that will be helpful for students’ future professional lives. (*Ibid.*, p. 100)

The OECD is once again promoting in-depth practices centered on the learner while suggesting that, because of their virtues, they should be used more widely in all disciplines. Finally, the percentage of variation in practices among countries, schools, and classrooms is also presented: “countries differ especially with regard to the frequency of enhanced activities, whereas structuring activities seem to be about equally popular across countries” (*ibid.*, p. 101). Despite a certain degree of variance between teachers and disciplines, structured teaching approaches are more widely used in classrooms. In order to balance the vast array of practices among teachers, the OECD recommends giving a greater role to the two other types of practices.

Analysis of Recommendation

To round off its analysis, the OECD (2009c, 2012b) brings forth a series of recommendations while identifying their political and practical implication. Here is the first one: “Teachers generally support modern constructivist beliefs about instruction, but there is scope for strengthening this support” (OECD, 2009c, p. 120). The discussion which follows this first

recommendation outlines the OECD's current pedagogical position with regard to teacher training:

Throughout the world educationalists and teacher instructors promote constructivist views about instruction. While most teachers agree, their preferences, influenced by individual characteristics, vary greatly within each country and school. If policy seeks to support constructivist positions, a promising strategy might be to enhance the systematic construction of knowledge about teaching and instruction in teachers' initial education and professional development. Interventions may be especially important for experienced teachers and for those who teach subjects other than mathematics. (*Ibid.*)

Its orientation could not be any clearer: initial training and professional development of teachers must make them conversant with "(socio)-constructivist practices." This position is reiterated strongly on the next page: "Professional development might be one way to boost teachers' use of student-oriented practices and enhanced activities" (*ibid.*, p. 121).

After careful reading of the various documents related to TALIS, we can state that this recommendation is not founded on evidence-based research. Studies mentioned in the various reports confirm the popularity of constructivism and the existence of a teaching effect, but they bring no tangible proof of the effectiveness of the three types of practices. On the other hand, the start of the third sentence – "If policy seeks to support constructivist positions" – also attracts attention. Through it, the OECD walks away from a position in favor of constructivism, but which other alternative does the organization propose in a concrete fashion? In other words, if a country categorically refuses to align itself with constructivism, what does it have left to do? As we have seen, what is left is a series of peripheral practices which, at best, will allow teachers to start and end their lessons.

The second recommendation to examine is the second one: "Teachers need to use a wider range of instructional strategies and techniques" (OECD, 2009c, p. 121). Here, the discussion which surrounds it gives numerous indications which confirm the pedagogical position defended within the report. The following excerpt first attracts our attention:

The aspect which most differentiates teaching styles in different countries is the use of a variety of enhanced learning activities – the least common of the three instructional approaches identified by TALIS. In particular in countries where these activities are relatively less frequently used, it seems advisable to help teachers of all subjects, but especially those teaching mathematics and science, to acquire and implement a wider variety of modern instructional strategies. (*Ibid.*)

This short paragraph summarizes some of the observations noted previously, including a black-and-white way of thinking along the lines that since

in-depth practices are herein assimilated to modern teaching practices, it can be deduced that structured practices are not modern teaching practices, or are less so. But in a world where the word “innovation” is so bandied about, being associated to traditional practices may not be so favorable.

It is also noted that the OECD is continuing along its conversion mission by trying to introduce in-depth practices where they were not yet present, meaning in the fields of mathematics and science. In order to do so, the correlation between differentiated instruction and the use of in-depth practices becomes very useful, and since “(socio)-constructivism” has brought about a wide variety of practices,⁷ it also gains an advantage on direct transmission as far as differentiated instruction is concerned. But does quantity also mean quality? Is the creation of a uniform teaching model where each segment would be tested before being integrated to be condemned because it does not, first and foremost, answer a desire for differentiated instruction? But finally, and more importantly, who made this recommendation? The way in which the authors phrased it: “It seems to be recommended to,” gives no clue as to who is recommending it.

In the discussion which accompanies the recommendations, the authors mention a series of individual and contextual factors which justify the need for teachers to adapt their teaching: local and cultural particularities, academic, social and language background of the students, teaching level, classrooms’ general aptitudes level, number of students in the classroom, etc. Earlier in the text, the authors already argued in favor of a differentiated approach which took into consideration the students’ aptitudes: “studies on aptitude-treatment interactions suggest that students with low intellectual abilities profit more from structured, teacher-centered instruction, while students with high intellectual abilities may gain more from less structured and more complex instruction (Snow & Lohman, 1984)” (*ibid.*, p. 90).

It is therefore surprising that the authors do not disagree with the following excerpt: “In classes with a high proportion of students with a migration background or a minority status – as indicated by a first language other than the language of instruction – more student-oriented practices are used” (*ibid.*, p. 121). Except for exceptional cases, a mother tongue which differs from the language of instruction predicts serious learning difficulties. In such a situation, would learner-centered practices not be less recommended than structured learning practices? The OECD answers this question thusly:

Such adaptation may be encouraged [here, the authors refer to in-depth practices with gifted students and to learner-centered practices with those who have a mother tongue different from the language of instruction], as it helps provide students with appropriate levels of cognitive challenge and supportive practices. However, to work towards equality

of learning opportunities, teacher education and professional development need to find new ways of expanding the use of enhanced activities for all students, independent of their ability. For example, peer learning and peer tutoring can improve learning outcomes, especially for students with learning difficulties (Topping, 2005). (*Ibid.*)

This excerpt reflects the thought process of the various reports linked to the TALIS survey. We find that structured practices are not a serious option and that, in fact, the OECD advocates for adopting in-depth practices in all disciplines and for all students, whatever their aptitude level.

Let us end our analysis of recommendations on this other section of the discussion:

It would, however, be wrong simply to introduce constructivism. Teachers need to be convinced that they can be successful in communicating deep content and in involving students in cognitively demanding activities, thereby following constructivist principles, while maintaining a positive disciplinary climate and providing student-oriented support. None of the basic dimensions of educational quality can be dispensed with. Fostering constructivist beliefs and enhanced activities is an important goal for professional development, but care should be taken to emphasise broad teaching practices, including structured teaching and self-regulatory learning. Depending on cultural traditions, and also on the stages of the learning process, various approaches should be applied to suit the circumstances. An example is starting a lesson with more direct teaching and gradually creating more open learning situations (fading), while working in a more structured way with weaker students. (*Ibid.*, p. 121)

While continuing to stress the importance of promoting “(socio)-constructivist” beliefs and practices, the OECD reiterates that they are not sufficient; this brings back the principle of complementarity. This so-called happy ending nevertheless hides a pernicious effect since, by finally stating that many elements are required to provide quality instruction (pedagogical pluralism), the question of effective instruction practices is evacuated and this leaves the classroom door wide open to practices whose positive impact has not yet been proven on students’ learning. Furthermore, this final attempt at conciliation should not obscure the fact that the meaning of the pedagogical conversion proposed by the OECD is essentially directed at learner-centered, so-called in-depth practices.

INTERVIEW RESULTS

The data collected during the interviews with the three members of the TALIS team (P1, P2, and P3) shed some light on the documentary analysis. We were able to gather further information on the organization’s

operations, on how its members consider their work and their relationship with research. In this section, we will report solely on that portion of our discussions which dealt with teaching (Question 1 of the interview grid) and use of research evidence (section 2 of the interview grid).

Earlier in the chapter, we explained how the OECD encourages those countries which participate in TALIS to compensate for the wider usage of structured teaching practices by relying more on in-depth practices for all disciplines and with all students. The three participants who were interviewed did not agree with our interpretation of the study's results. For example, when we presented our thoughts on TALIS's conceptual framework and results to P2, he failed to recognize the study's conclusions in our rhetoric. P1 and P3 also felt the same and explained, as did P2, that the study rather recommends a combination of structured and "(socio)-constructivist" approaches: "I would say that the position in this report, and even more in the thematic report, is in fact that a combination of both which is required. That's because both types of teaching methods are required in some contexts since it's that combination of the two types of teaching approaches which offers the best results in general (P1)." This situation naturally puts into question the work we did on the documentary analysis.

Was that second ideological framework a figment of our imagination? The other possibility would be that, through their lack of teaching expertise, conceded at the outset by P1, P2, and P3, the three respondents had not noticed the second framework constructed by those experts⁸ they designated to establish the pedagogical section of TALIS's conceptual framework.

The three participants do not exactly justify in the same manner what P2 terms a "balancing act" and which visibly corresponds to the teaching position adopted by the OECD. P1 and P3 present two complementary arguments to justify the absence of a choice between instructionist approaches and other, more open approaches. Both start by underlining the limits of the TALIS survey with regard to evaluating the effectiveness of teaching methods⁹:

We are not inside the classroom. We can say what teachers believe, meaning that it is important to use a good variety of techniques, whether they be more "traditional" or more "constructivist" [...] Teachers who use a variety of teaching methods are often more self-confident and derive greater satisfaction at work, but again, I cannot say which types of techniques work best because we have no data linking teaching methods to students' results. (P1)

P1 outlines that teacher self-confidence and satisfaction are factors which cannot be used to directly predict their effectiveness and that it is the

reason why he “hesitates,” why he cannot say that “one teaching method is the best one to use in a given context,” that he “doesn’t know.” But research data produced by academics make it impossible to go beyond the limits of the OECD’s data or to fill the gaps within.

The impossibility for academic research to demonstrate the superiority of one teaching approach over another constitutes a strong argument for both participants: “we recognize that a debate still rages on in the academic literature on this topic since some are firmly entrenched to the right or to the left of the issue” (P1); “we cannot really say that one practice is better than another [...] We are still unable to say or to show through research that it is because such and such a teacher uses one particular method that his or her students have better results on a given topic” (P3). Whereas for P1 and P3, the impossibility to settle that teaching debate stems from the absence of research-driven data, P2 explains that, on the other hand, this “balancing act” corresponds to a construct based on existing literature. For him, research has proven the effectiveness of the various approaches discussed during the interview and in this regard, promoting only one option would constitute a bias. On the other hand, all three participants agree on the contextualized character of the act of teaching which is culture-based, all of which makes them even more prudent when formulating recommendations with regard to teaching methods. He noted that this characteristic of teaching is also mentioned by respondents of the other two profiles.

According to P3, the term “balancing act” represents a working philosophy in place at the OECD and which, in fact, translates the idea of a necessary adjustment between research data, the expectations of participating countries, as well as their technical and financial possibilities. These adjustments clearly show that educational policy making is not a simple or linear process. Various types of arguments – economic, social, organizational, political, cultural, ideological – not just scientific, can also guide educational policies, as part of a complex dynamics involving policy makers, politicians, administrators, stakeholders, media, etc. (Sabatier, 1999). That said, only the argument concerning the limits of TALIS seems to justify the “balancing act” as a working philosophy. The other two arguments – research is unable to demonstrate the superiority of one approach over another (P1 and P3) or, conversely, it has already attested to the effectiveness of all the practices advocated in the project TALIS (P2) – seem more difficult to defend when analyzing teaching practices from an evidence-based perspective.

CONCLUSION

We asked two questions in the introduction to this chapter, and we can now answer them. Within the TALIS initiative, the OECD transmits specific orientations which are not directly perceptible since at first view, it is rather the principle of complementarity in approaches which is valued. This principle rests on three apparently very simple arguments (OECD, 2012a): (1) there is no single method which can be used for teaching well, (2) good teachers must have a wide variety of practices at their disposal in order to adapt their teaching to the specific needs of their students, and (3) it is important to respect the professional autonomy of teachers. However, a second reading allows for the identification of a breach in the principle of complementarity put forth by the organization and it becomes clear that in reality, the autonomy of teachers is geared to “(socio)-constructivist” principles and practices. As for whether or not this pedagogical position is founded on evidence-based research, nothing in the documents reviewed allows for a confirmation. Furthermore, the authors of those reports identify “(socio)-constructivist” practices as standard practices which fall under the aegis of teaching philosophy rather than evidence-based education.

This pedagogical position is both problematic and paradoxical. Problematic in the sense that it pushes the OECD to remove itself from the pedagogical side of the reforms it oversees to rather rely on national experts whose expertise it cannot ascertain because of its lack of expertise. If the OECD refuses to better define its pedagogical guidelines, others will define them with the risk of putting in place inefficient educational methods. Its pedagogical stand is also paradoxical in that, just as is the case with other international organizations, the OECD is firmly entrenched in the principles of evidence-based policy which it uses as the main tool in its arsenal when meeting decision-makers (OECD, 2003, 2005c, 2007).

It is legitimate to question why it should place on the back burner any evidence-based research on teaching effectiveness in order to promote educational principles and practices it considers as being unfounded. By way of a response, Schweisfurth (2013) explains that “[r]ather than providing empirical evidence on LCE’s desirability, much of literature appeals to theory, or to rights. The evidence-based paradigm is only one way of viewing the question of LCE’s place and there is no reason to treat theoretical link or, as outlined below, rights-based approaches as less important” (p. 129). Thus, the universality of certain fundamental rights – such as the professional autonomy of teachers and the development of the whole child – would suffice to legitimize the value of learner-centered approaches.

In short, divided between the wish to improve the quality of teachers and the principles of a pedagogical position which rejects best practices, the OECD is in a deadlock and, in order to move forward, it will have to look further than the false paradigmatic opposition which structures the pedagogical debate in order to follow another road, one which will value the use of evidence-based research with regard to teaching effectiveness.

NOTES

1. This project gave rise to 25 reports by participating countries, to 10 reports by external investigating teams which worked on-site, and to numerous research summaries required of experts (OECD, 2005a).

2. In the 1980s, the theory of human capital became central in the argument to defend the considerable weight of education in the economic growth of a nation: "the availability of human resources, which is a critical element in determining the rate of development generally, is even more important in the context of the global economy" (Stewart, 1996, p. 331).

3. Because the first results of TALIS 2013 will be officially published in the spring of 2014, the following analysis does not include results of this second study. It rather examines the common analytical framework for both studies and the results of TALIS 2008. During the interviews, we also learned that important countries like the United States, Finland, or France, absent from 2008, will be included in TALIS 2013. Other countries interviewed in the first TALIS study have left in the wake of the world economic crisis of 2008. We also know that a TALIS 2018 is also in the plans.

4. This wording is rarely used but is culled from the conceptual framework of the TALIS initiative (OECD, 2012a). We have decided to use it in the text to designate everything which is not encompassed within the category of instructionist approaches.

5. Note that the documents published by international organizations may contain very varied themes. In many cases, reading from the first to the last line of a report would have proven counterproductive in that it would have distracted us from our research topic.

6. On this point, socio-constructivism has another clear advantage over direct transmission since, contrary to it, socio-constructivism may have given rise to numerous types of practices such as "self-directed learning", 'co-operative learning', 'self-regulated learning', 'guided discovery', 'scaffolding', 'cognitive apprenticeship', 'teacher-mediated dialogue', 'independent group discussion', 'problem-based learning', 'project-based learning', and 'knowledge building'" (OECD, 2012b, p. 29).

7. "Self-directed learning", 'co-operative learning', 'self-regulated learning', 'guided discovery', 'scaffolding', 'cognitive apprenticeship', 'teacher-mediated dialogue', 'independent group discussion', 'problem-based learning', "project-based learning", and 'knowledge building'" (OECD, 2012b, p. 29).

8. A group of German experts headed by Eckhard Klieme (see [Klieme, Lipowsky, Rakoczy, & Ratzka, 2006](#)).

9. Limits on which they are currently trying to overcome with a video project in which they observe teachers at work.

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